

Article

Analysis of Consumer Attitudes as an Important Tool for the Segmentation and Development of the Game Market in the Czech Republic

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Abstract: The demand for the multipurpose use of forestry accentuates the development of non-timber forest products and services and the search for other sources of financial benefits for forest owners and users. One of the essential market items of non-timber forest production is game production, a very high-quality local food source. Currently, in the Czech Republic, as well as in neighbouring countries, the amount of game being offered is increasing, while the purchase prices of game have stagnated at very low levels for a long time, despite the fact that consumer prices of meat have generally increased. A prerequisite for the development of the market for game products and the effective use of marketing tools is the analysis of important factors influencing the consumer demand for game. Therefore, the possible limiting factors on the customer side, the removal of which can change the demand for game meat and increase the consumption of game production, were investigated. Igor Ansoff's approach is used to analyse growth opportunities in the game market from the point of view of marketing strategies. The preconditions for using Porter's STP process to design a pull strategy on the consumer market are verified. Based on the Parfitt–Collins model, the research mainly focuses on a sample of active consumers who are a subgroup of a representative panel of 1000 respondents. The demographic characteristics and buying behaviour of the subgroup of 523 active consumers who regularly consume game meat were analysed. Significant factors and potential segmentation criteria were identified. On the basis of these research results, the article discusses, in detail, the marketing aspects related to the development of the game market, and marketing procedures are also proposed that can significantly support consumer demand in the game market using a mix of marketing tools. The increased demand for game meat will help to reduce the overpopulation of cloven-hoofed game in the forests of the Czech Republic, which will positively impact the reduction of animal damage to the forest environment, especially in areas newly forested after the bark beetle calamity.

Keywords: game marketing; game management; forest damage; game meat production; non-timber forest production



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1. Introduction

The gradually changing face of human society brings new challenges for the environment and forest management in developed countries. Forest production is consistently being translated into a stream of services provided for society [1]. In the last two decades, three major classifications of ecosystem services have evolved, namely MEA [2], The Economics of Ecosystems and Biodiversity (TEEB) [3], and The Common International Classification of Ecosystem Services (CICES) [4].

The systematics, in general, divide tangible forest provisioning services into two main categories of interest. The first one relates to the production of timber, and the second one relates to the remaining products and services of the forest except for timber production.

Non-timber forest products (NTFPs), in this respect, are a widely discussed topic outlined by the definition that encompasses all biological materials other than timber that are extracted from forests for human use [5].

Although forest management is slowly transforming from serving a timber production function to having a multipurpose use [6], which includes NTFP products and services [7], this area is new and unexplored for many owners [8]. For this reason, there is a demand for information that helps owners transform forest management into having a multipurpose use [9].

The growing importance of NTFPs has been followed up by numerous studies focusing on the financial inflow into forestry and its evaluation, for example [10–12], among others. The degree of importance of individual NTFPs varies greatly geographically. In Central Europe, fall forest fruits, mushrooms, medicinal plants, decorative fruits, and game [13,14] are among the most frequently collected NTFP products. Some of those products are available to the public free of charge (with limits depending on the country); some are subject to market exchange as alternatives to agricultural products [15].

Game is characterised by its nutritional value and specific taste [16]. In terms of nutrition, reference [17] stipulates that game is characterized by its lower fat content compared to beef, pork, and lamb. Moreover, the nutritional value is considered high due to its high protein content and high amounts of minerals, vitamins, trace elements, and unsaturated fatty acids.

This fact is also confirmed by other studies, e.g., [18–20], evidencing the versatility of the overall health-related benefits of game meat in detail. Game is a natural product that, in addition to its nutritional value and naturally organic origin, also represents a culturally conditioned approach to its consumption. Multiple social factors directly impact its consumption, such as health concerns, animal welfare, and a hunting culture [21]; conversely, hunting for game production could be understood as a part of one's cultural heritage [22]. Several studies have dealt with income based on game production [22–24], emphasising the fact that game hunting provides numerous benefits to local economies and communities as it provides additional sources of income to forest owners. It has the potential to create sustainable value chains and become beneficial for rural areas with limited employment opportunities. Creating a regular source of financial income from market game production is a challenge for forestry. Game marketing and production are the limiting factors that follow the nature of this product [25–27]. Specifically, these factors are the format of the game product, its availability (in time and volume), product quality, value-chain price differentiation, and distribution channels [28].

A significant proportion of game is purchased through social ties; however, studies documenting the movement of game across society are not available. Understanding the key factors on the market demand side provides an opportunity to master sustainable access to natural resources, including the game itself [29].

The development of the game market is in the interest of both the forestry and agricultural sectors due to the protection of forest stands and agricultural products from any damage caused by wild animals [30], and, from the point of view of increasing the quality of the population's nutrition [17,27,31,32], relevant studies have highlighted that game meat can be an excellent addition to a population's nutrition. It is rich in quality proteins and essential vitamins and minerals, and sourcing local game meat can help support local producers and the environment. In addition, for these reasons, this article focuses on an analysis of the factors that would contribute to the development of the game market in the example of the Czech Republic, especially in the form of an increase in consumer demand for game. The analysis of this primary (consumer) demand is key, because the demand of processors and distributors from the producers (hunters in this case) throughout the entire value chain is derived from consumer demand (the so-called derived demand) [33,34]. This consumer demand is the most significant factor that determines the dynamics of the market and its further development [35]. If a combination of different forms of communication is used to increase consumer demand, it is a so-called pull strategy [36].

Analysing growth opportunities in the game market from the point of view of marketing strategies, Igor Ansoff's approach is often used [37,38]. The Ansoff matrix breaks down market growth options in relation to new products and markets, as well as existing products and markets. It is a square table that has two axes: a horizontal one with products that are divided into "existing" and "new" ones; and a vertical one with markets that are also divided into "existing" and "new" ones. These two axes of the Ansoff matrix create four quadrants that include all the possible combinations of "existing" and "new" products and markets corresponding to one of four possible marketing strategies:

- Market penetration strategy ("existing product/existing market").
- Market development strategy ("existing product/new market").
- Product development strategy ("new product/existing market").
- Diversification strategy ("new product/new market").

Given that the markets in the neighbouring countries of the Czech Republic (CZ) are supplied with a growing supply of game from local sources [24], Ansoff's growth strategy of penetrating the domestic market in combination with partial product innovation comes into consideration.

As the game market is part of the meat market, the effort to increase the domestic game market means, from a marketing point of view, increasing the market share of game in the overall domestic meat market. From a conceptual point of view and for estimating a possible increase in the market share, it is advantageous to use the classic Parfitt–Collins approach [39,40] that decomposes the market share into three essential, meaningful variables related to consumer demand that can explain what is causing changes in the market share of an analysed product or commodity. The Parfitt and Collins model, further explained in the Materials and Methods section, is a relatively simple formula. It follows from the formula that increasing the market share of game meat consumption is a direct consequence of increasing the volume of the consumer demand for game. Therefore, the basic prerequisite for Ansoff's penetration and an increase in the market size is an increase in demand in the consumer market [41,42].

Suppose Michael Porter's approach [43,44] to create a long-term competitive strategy is used. His generic strategies are low cost, differentiation, and focus [45,46]. In the case of the game market, strategy differentiation with a focus on specific parts of the market comes into consideration. Philip Kotler proposed the segmentation, targeting, and positioning (STP) strategy as a marketing strategy in the consumer market [47–49]. It is a systematic approach to creating a marketing strategy, including three stages: segmenting (i.e., market segmentation), targeting (selection of target segments), and positioning (choice of positioning on selected segments). Many successful companies use the STP strategy in the consumer market, viz. [50–52]. An analysis of the possibilities of using the potential of the STP strategy and the possibilities of differentiation for the development of the game market is also the starting point for the formulation of the research questions listed below. These questions focus on verifying the existence of factors that could be used for differentiation based on consumer characteristics and adequate combinations of marketing mix tools.

Research Questions

1. Are there significant differences in game consumers given their demographic characteristics?
2. Are there limiting factors on the customer side, the removal of which can more fundamentally change the demand for game on the consumer market side?
3. What marketing tools can significantly influence consumer demand in the game market?

Game in the Czech Republic

The research area covers the Czech Republic (CZ), a Central European country with 10 million inhabitants. Hunting is regulated in the Czech Republic by the Hunting Act no. 449/2001 and several ministerial decrees, such as the specification of hunting seasons

regulation of the Ministry of Agriculture 245/2002 Sb., the detailed instructions regulation of the Ministry of Agriculture 244/2002 Sb., and some others.

The central authority for hunting control and game management is the Ministry of Agriculture, except for the land in the national parks, which is subordinated to the Ministry of the Environment. The local and regional authorities execute the power of the state's administration of the game management on the territory of the administrative regions.

The Ministry of Agriculture and the Czech Statistical Office collected the main statistics.

In 2020, the country registered 5786 hunting grounds, where 751 were managed by the owner and 5035 were rented [53,54].

CZ forestland covers 2,671,700 ha, i.e., 33.9% of the total area of the CZ. There is 6,887,798 ha of hunting land in the Czech Republic (38% forest land, 57% agricultural land, 6% water areas and other land). In 2021, 16.7 thousand tonnes of cloven-hoofed game were produced in the Czech Republic, of which 69% was wild boar (*Sus scrofa*) [53,54]. The total production of game in the Czech Republic is around 18,000 tonnes/year and has been increasing for a long time [55].

As shown in Table 1, the selected ungulates in the Czech Republic represent more than 90% of the total game production by volume. It is clear from the development of the historical time series that there has been a consistent increase in the spring conditions of game and hunting.

Table 1. Selected ungulates in Czech Republic hunting statistics (in pieces/whole carcasses) [55].

Item		2011	2013	2015	2017	2019	2021
Red deer (<i>Cervus elaphus</i>)	Spring count	30,838	26,618	28,223	29,789	29,773	31,916
	Hunt	20,958	23,578	23,978	27,878	29,017	30,792
Fallow deer (<i>Dama dama</i>)	Spring count	26,611	27,774	31,099	33,734	37,799	41,663
	Hunt	13,131	16,404	18,968	23,069	28,978	33,250
European mouflon (<i>Ovis musimon</i>)	Spring count	21,294	19,435	20,471	21,707	20,949	22,730
	Hunt	8146	9222	9495	9400	10,105	10,019
Roe deer (<i>Capreolus capreolus</i>)	Spring count	302,206	290,661	291,241	298,852	291,070	293,565
	Hunt	113,913	105,680	99,828	103,455	103,018	107,433
Wild boar (<i>Sus scrofa</i>)	Spring count	59,295	59,175	60,966	58,746	60,863	62,676
	Hunt	109,383	152,250	185,496	229,182	239,818	230,905

The spring state of the ungulates is determined with direct observation in the months of January and February.

According to the Ministry of Agriculture, the high numbers of forest animals and the need to restore Czech forests with varied tree compositions and with an increased proportion of deciduous trees (which are particularly sensitive to animal damage) are the reasons for supporting the decision to significantly decrease game numbers [54]. Deciduous trees also include pioneer tree species. As a result, these factors have increased the supply of game not only in the Czech market but also in neighbouring countries [24].

Meat consumption in the Czech Republic has long been around 80 kg/year/capita (Figure 1) [56]. Of this, game consumption represents around 1 kg, i.e., a very low share at around 1.2% of the total meat consumption [57]. This consumption is comparable to the share of consumption in neighbouring countries, as can be seen, for example, from [26].

Game production is also significant in neighbouring countries, which, in some cases, greatly exceeds the production in the Czech Republic, such as in Poland and Germany (Table 2) [24,58,59]. However, the calculated number of pieces caught per 1000 people in the Czech Republic is comparable to and, for some species, even higher than in the neighbouring countries (Table 3).

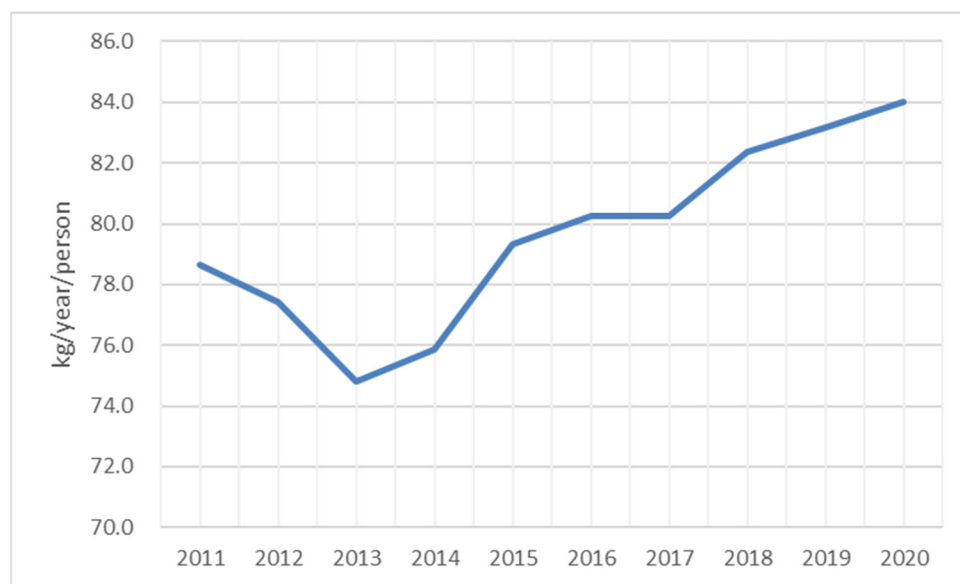


Figure 1. Meat consumption in the Czech Republic per capita [56].

Table 2. Selected ungulates in Czech Republic hunting statistics (in pieces).

2019 Harvest in Pcs	Czech Republic	Poland	Germany
Red deer (<i>Cervus elaphus</i>)	29,863	98,877	76,897
Fallow deer (<i>Dama dama</i>)	31,057	8664	68,211
Roe deer (<i>Capreolus capreolus</i>)	105,665	192,850	1,226,169
Wild boar (<i>Sus scrofa</i>)	161,699	331 886	882,231

Table 3. Selected ungulates harvested per 1000 capita (comparison-adjusted per 1000 capita).

2019 Harvest in Pcs	Czech Republic	Poland	Germany
Red deer (<i>Cervus elaphus</i>)	2.8	2.6	0.9
Fallow deer (<i>Dama dama</i>)	2.9	0.2	0.8
Roe deer (<i>Capreolus capreolus</i>)	9.9	5.1	14.7
Wild boar (<i>Sus scrofa</i>)	15.1	8.8	10.6

Despite the high inflation, the purchase price of the game offered by the processing and distribution channels in the Czech Republic is lower than in previous years or is stagnant.

For example, the purchasing price for 1 kg of wild boar was around 40 CZK in 2000. In 2022, the purchasing price was around 35 CZK [60], while the selling price of game to end customers offered by the shops and distribution channels was 175–380 CZK per kg [61]. Hunting, thus, instead of contributing to forestry income, has become an unprofitable activity. This is a long-term trend that can be documented, for example, in the development of prices and the decreasing number of people interested in hunting [55,62].

2. Materials and Methods

The work can be methodically divided into four phases:

- Selection of the target segment for research;
- Survey organisation;
- Statistical analysis;
- Interpretation of the data obtained by the research.

2.1. Selection of the Target Segment for Research

As mentioned in the introductory section, from a conceptual point of view, it is suitable to use the classic Parfitt–Collins formula [39,40], because it enables one to systematically

analyse the basic factors influencing the size of consumer demand (see Formula 1). Because the Parfitt–Collins formula is a product of three factors, it is clear that increasing the market share of meat consumption and increasing the volume of consumer demand for game can be achieved by increasing any indicator P , R , or B . To choose the target segment for the analysis, parameter P is crucial: cumulative penetration, which expresses, in our case, the share of customers who have ever bought and tasted game, as the content of this research is focused on the analysis of active customers who are part of cumulative penetration. The possibilities of increasing the cumulative penetration indicator P will be the subject of further research, which can also be very challenging in the case of game, because the reasons that have led a potential customer to have never tasted game before can be very diverse. Those reasons can often be related to strong attitudes or prejudices that marketing tools cannot change, for example, if the person in question is a vegetarian or has a strong attitude towards hunting, worries about forest animals, or experienced a different upbringing and was raised in a different culinary practice [63].

The advantage of the mentioned procedure is that it also enables one to conceptually differentiate and analyse the demand potential for game among those customers who are part of the cumulative penetration and whose demand depends on the frequency and intensity of their purchasing from the demand potential for game of those who have not yet become customers.

Parfitt–Collins Formula:

$$\text{Market Share} = P * R * B \quad (1)$$

where P = Cumulative product penetration (percentage of consumers who have purchased venison at least once); R = Repeat purchasing rates (average percentage of repurchases made by consumers of the product); and B = Buying Index or the heaviness of buying.

The research, therefore, focuses on a more detailed analysis of the segment of customers who actively purchase and consume meat and meat dishes with the aim of obtaining information on how to use marketing mix tools to increase the R (repeat purchasing rates) or B (the heaviness of buying). On the basis of the achieved results, follow-up research can be planned regarding the refinement of the segmentation criteria and the increase in cumulative penetration, the results of which will be the content of another professional article.

2.2. Survey Organisation

The research was carried out by a professional research agency using Computer-Assisted Web Interviewing (CAWI) (see, e.g., [64]) from 24 August to 30 August 2021. The respondents were part of the Czech National Panel, a joint project of the research agencies NMS Market Research, Nielsen Admosphere, and STEM/MARK. From a sample of 1000 respondents, who were representative in terms of their gender, age, education, region, and the size of their place of residence, the target group of respondents was selected. The target group consists of respondents who consume meat, actively shop or visit restaurants, have mostly tasted game, and are over 20 years old (a prerequisite for independent shopping and decision-making). The structure of the sample is shown in Table 4. The research agency guarantees the data representativeness following the European Society for Opinion and Marketing Research (ESOMAR) Standards.

Table 4. Structure of the sample (number of respondents $n = 523$).

Gender	Male	266
	Female	257
Age category	20–29 years old	84
	30–39 years old	137
	40–49 years old	136
	50 or more years	166

Table 4. *Cont.*

Highest completed education	Elementary school/secondary school without high school diploma	95
	Secondary school with high school diploma	261
	University/Higher vocational school	167
Region of the Czech Republic	Prague and the Central Bohemian Region	169
	Bohemia	162
	Moravia	192
Place of residence	Village	153
	Small and medium-sized cities	199
	Big cities	171

2.3. Statistical Analysis

The demographical data characterising the respondents were collected as a part of the survey.

Because of this fact, the data were able to be further examined using methods of categorical data analysis and contingency tables [65]. The analysed categories were created using the following statistical variables: age of respondent, gender, completed education, size of the community, and region of the CZ. The variables corresponding to those categories are a standard part of the survey, and the research agencies guarantee that the sample is representative of these demographic variables. These categories were the subject of a statistical examination using R software [66] to test the p values corresponding to the hypothesis of independence using a chi-squared distribution. The p value is a random variable derived from the distribution of the test statistics used to analyse a data set and test the null hypothesis [67].

In this article, in addition to traditional tables, the mosaic displays designed in [68] and extended in [69] are used for greater clarity. The use of this advanced graphical method when analysing the dependence of several categorical variables simplifies data interpretation, as this method of visualisation helps to understand the relationships between the individual factors better than traditional graphs [70]. The counts in the contingency table are represented by tiles whose size is proportional to the cell frequency. The hypothesized model is based on the independence of the variables, which means the cells in the same row should have the same height regardless of the explaining variable. The differences in the sizes then clearly signal mutual conditionality and dependence, the degree of statistical significance of which is verified using the above-mentioned method. The following variables were used in the mosaic displays: frequency of game consumption, type of game purchased, age and gender of the respondent, and his/her size of residence.

3. Results and Discussion

The results of the research point to significant consumer experience of those interviewed with the consumption of game, where only 21% of the respondents indicated that they do not consume game at all, and approximately 50% of those interviewed consume game both at home and in a restaurant.

Table 5 shows the differences between men and women, who consume game only in restaurants or do not consume at all. This difference is also statistically significant. The corresponding p value of the test is 0.00018 (chi-square value = 19.88, degrees of freedom = 3, sample size = 523). Out of 257 women, 25% do not consume game at all, while 17% of the 266 men in the group do not consume game, thus showing a significant proportion of women who do not consume game compared to men. The share of women that do not consume game or only consume it in restaurants is significantly higher than that of men. This finding is in line with other research studies, which have stated a generally higher level of game consumption in men compared to women [71,72].

Table 5. Do you eat game-based foods (including pâté, sausages, etc.) ($n = 523$)?

Gender	Yes, I Consume at Home and in Restaurants	Yes, I Only Consume at Home	Yes, I Only Consume in Restaurants	I Do Not Consume
Male	49.9%	23.7%	9.5%	16.9%
Female	49.1%	10.8%	15.2%	24.8%

The individual categories related to purchase frequency are relatively evenly distributed and do not significantly differ even for the individual types of purchased commodities as apparent in Table 6.

Table 6. What kind of game or game-based food do you buy (whether for yourself or members of your household) ($n = 523$)?

Product	At Least Once a Week	At Least Once a Month	At Least Once Every 3 Months	At Least Once a Year	Less Often	Never
Meat	17.1%	15.0%	21.9%	16.7%	12.2%	17.1%
Cold meats (sausages, salami, etc.)	18.7%	19.5%	20.2%	11.6%	15.1%	14.8%
Pies	10.3%	25.8%	20.9%	13.2%	13.5%	16.4%
Other	6.3%	7.8%	8.4%	8.8%	26.3%	42.3%

The above data also show the high potential for an increase in the overall consumer demand of over 20% if marketing activities can be used to increase the frequency of the categories with a lower shopping frequency, i.e., “at least once every 3 months”, “at least once a year”, and “less often”, which represent $21.9\% + 16.7\% + 12.2\% = 50.8\%$ of the respondents, moving one category to the left.

If a more detailed segmentation of purchasing behaviour by age category is analysed, see Figure 2, a statistically significant dependence of the frequency of game purchases based on age group can be identified. The chi-square test has a p value = 4×10^{-6} (chi-square value = 47.26, degrees of freedom = 12).

The analysis shows a very strong group of shoppers in the 20–29 (at least once a week) and 50 and over (at least once every three months) age groups. Most respondents who do not buy game are in the 30–39 age group. Studies confirm that a frequent reason for the low consumption of game is concern about the specific taste [26,73,74]. To overcome this concern, it is advisable to maximise the consumer experience through tastings to increase the cumulative penetration of venison into the consumer market, which is confirmed by [75].

In Figure 3, one can compare the two mosaic displays analysing the relationship between the categorical variables: the type of purchased game and the age of the female and male respondents. In both cases, this dependence is statistically significant (men p value = 0.016, women p value = 0.265, chi-square value = 29.03/17.96, degrees of freedom = 15). Regarding the type of game, men consume more wild boar, while women consume a significantly larger share of game birds than men (Figure 3). As for game prepared at home, across the age groups, the most frequently prepared game was wild boar meat, followed by venison. In the age group of 30–39 years, roe deer equalled fallow deer in preparation volume. The differences visible in the mosaic display in Figure 4 are statistically significant (p -value = 0.029, chi-square value = 27.00, degrees of freedom = 15).

The dependence of the age group on the demand for a specific type of game turned out to be statistically significant (p value = 0.029). Thus, the demand for a particular type of meat depends on the age of the consumer. For example, previous studies [76,77] also mention this.

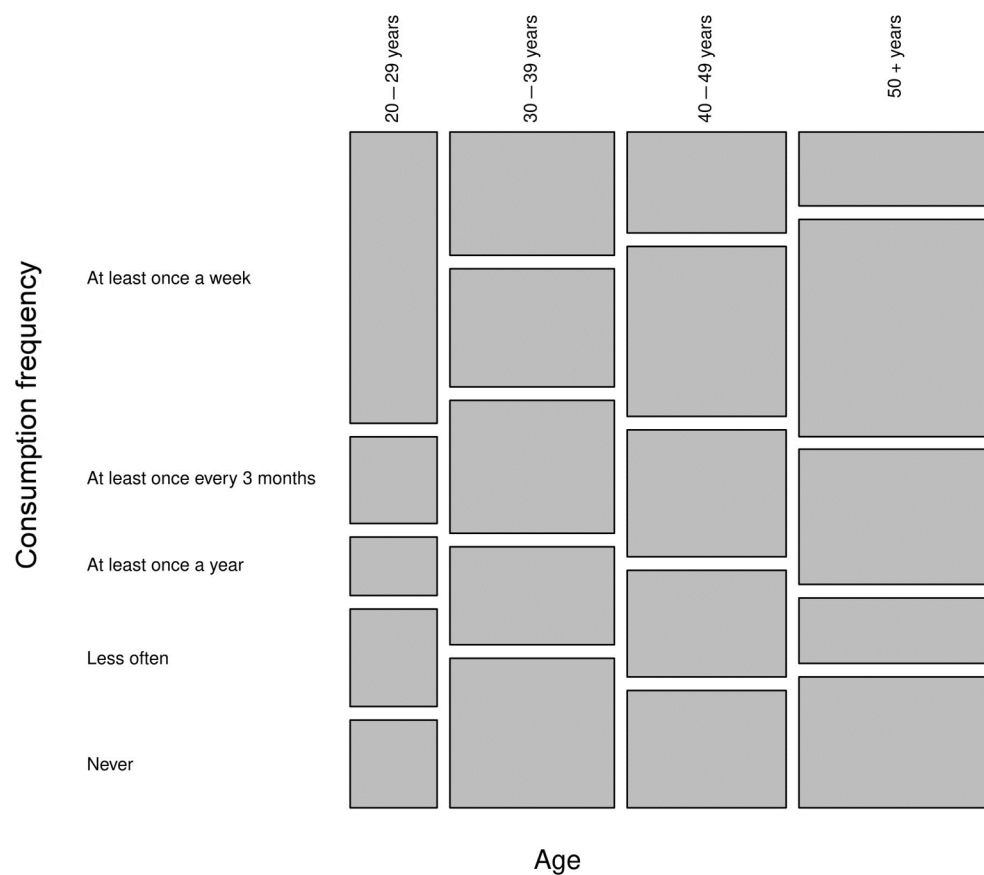


Figure 2. The mosaic display of the relationship between the respondent's age and consumption frequency ($n = 445$).

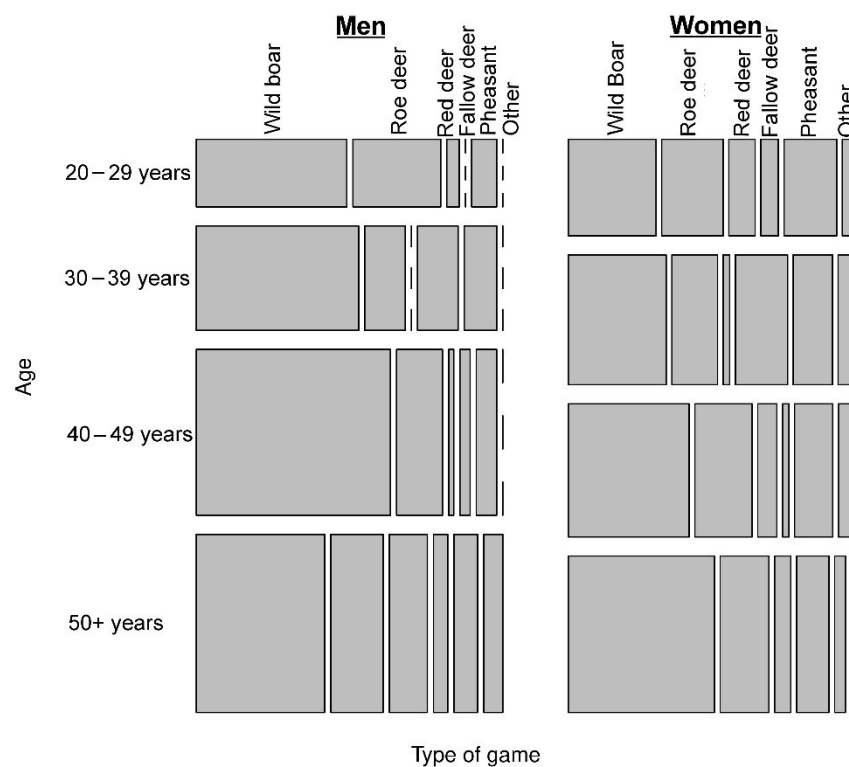


Figure 3. The mosaic displays the relationship between the respondent's age and the type of game cooked at home ($n_1 = 168$ Men, $n_2 = 155$ Women).

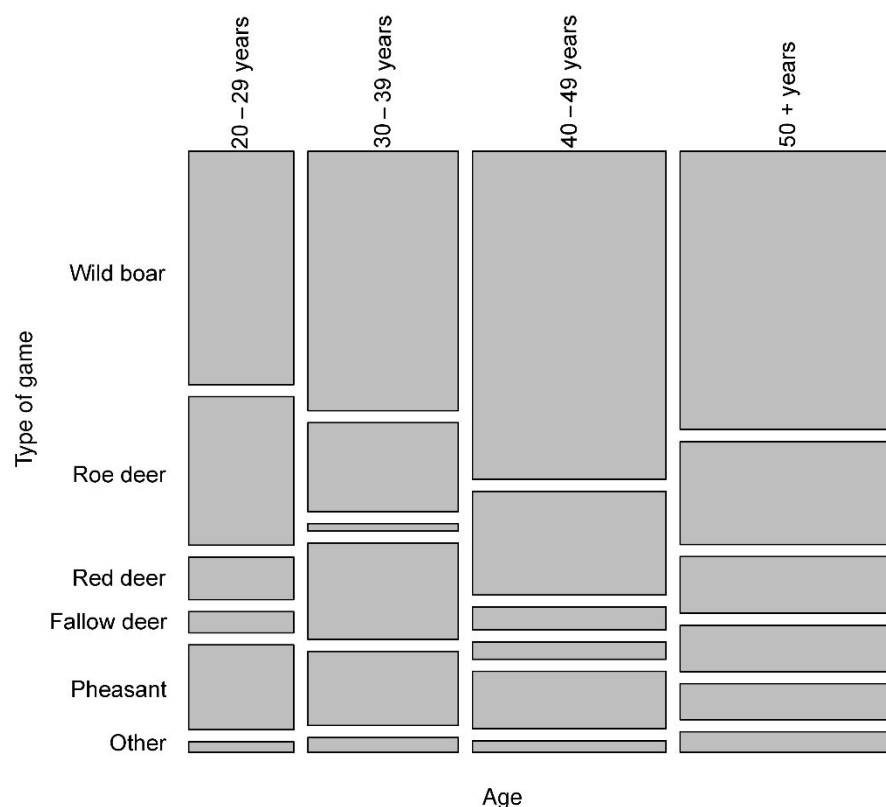


Figure 4. The mosaic displays the relationship between the respondent's age and the type of game cooked at home ($n = 323$).

On the basis of the research results, it can be stated that 84% of the respondents rather or completely consider game to be a healthy organic food. However, almost 60% of the answers are of the “rather agree” type, which is apparently not a strong enough perception of organic quality for them to be willing to pay a premium price for game. Furthermore, 75% of the respondents rather or completely consider game to be an ecologically friendly food. At the same time, 58% of the respondents rather or completely agree with the opinion that the consumption of game contributes to the development of forestry (see Table 7).

Table 7. Which of the following statements about game do you agree with ($n = 523$)?

Preference	It Is a Healthy Food in Organic Quality	It Is an Ecologically Friendly Food	By Consuming Game I Help the Czech Forests
I definitely agree	24.0%	16.6%	9.9%
I rather agree	59.9%	58.7%	48.2%
I rather disagree	11.9%	18.8%	30.5%
I definitely disagree	4.2%	5.9%	11.4%

The survey (see Table 8) also shows a significant demand for fresh, portioned venison $n = 433$ (68%), while the least interest is in frozen, portioned venison (9%). In addition, 11% of consumers expressed an interest in unprocessed meat, while 12% expressed an indifferent attitude.

The dependence of product processing and the size of the respondent's residence turned out to be statistically very high, with a p value = 0.00105 (chi-square value = 22.34, degrees of freedom = 6). In order to increase purchase intensity, it is necessary to make game commonly available in various forms for consumption (chilled, frozen, or semi-finished products) for the daily supply of households. This can increase the frequency of consumption and the related intensity of purchasing and consumption, which is confirmed by, for example, [25].

Table 8. When buying meat-game, you prefer ($n = 433$).

Place of Residence	Fresh Meat, Portioned	Fresh Meat, Unportioned (I Obtain and Portion it Myself)	Frozen Meat, Portioned	It Does Not Matter to Me
Village	69.2%	17.9%	4.8%	8.1%
Small and medium-sized cities	70.3%	9.4%	9.3%	11.0%
Big cities	65.3 %	7.3%	10.9%	16.6%

A detailed analysis of the dependence of the place of purchase on the size of the final consumer's residence points to a strong dependence between the choice of sales channel and the size of the respondent's residence (chi-square test: p -value = 0.0059; chi-square value = 24.71; degrees of freedom = 10). Our analysis shows that local hunters are mainly sought after by consumers from smaller settlements, while the supermarket/hypermarket is significantly chosen by residents of large cities (over 100,000 inhabitants).

The large share of local hunters on the supply side reflects the easiest way that hunters sell game meat. According to Czech legislation, there are more relaxed hygienic rules for users of the hunting grounds. Under the regulation, users of the hunting grounds can, in small quantities, sell directly to consumers. The condition for this simplified consumer distribution is that the place of sale must be located in the territory of the region in which the game was caught or in the neighbouring regions.

This study did not consider game meat being exchanged “for free” within the community or undeclared as a sale (grey market).

The population segments from [78] represent households according to socioeconomic status, from households with the highest socioeconomic status (A) to the poorest households (E), where the average income per person is presented as segment (C) (Table 9).

Table 9. What are the reasons why you do not eat game in a restaurant? (Base: 200 respondents either eat game food only at home or do not, multiple answers possible).

[79]	Offer It				
A,B–Highest	24.6%	15.0%	61.8%	23.4%	10.8%
C	34.2%	17.7%	55.1%	23.6%	10.5%
D,E–Lowest	33.7%	30.8%	38.0%	35.8%	2.3%
Total	30.6%	19.5%	54.0%	26.1%	8.9%

This research shows that for segments A and B, price is not a determining factor for not consuming game in a restaurant. This segment mainly mentions other personal preferences when choosing food in a restaurant. In segments D and E, there is a noticeable concern about the quality of the game offered in the restaurant for consumption. For this segment (low-income groups of the population), it can be hypothesised that this concern may be related to visiting lower-level restaurants and the resulting concerns regarding the origin and quality of the game processing. Because the test yielded a p value = 0.1433 (chi-square value = 12.18, degrees of freedom = 8), the hypothesis that the dependence between the stated arguments and the income segments of the population is random and cannot be rejected at a sufficient level of significance.

Roughly half of the population believes that game should be priced like other types of meat. If we analyse the differences between men and women, this difference is statistically very significant (p value = 0.00018, chi-square value = 17.26, degrees of freedom = 2). Over 43% of women believe that game should cost more than other types of meat (Table 10). From the above results, it is clear that there are significant differences between groups of game consumers due to their demographic and socioeconomic characteristics, which can be a starting point for effective market segmentation, as evidenced in the answer to the first research question.

Table 10. How do you perceive the price of game compared to other types of meat ($n = 523$)?

Gender	It Should Cost More than Other Types of Meat	It Should Cost the Same as Other Types of Meat	It Should Cost Less than Other Types of Meat
Male	26.3%	64.3%	9.5%
Female	43.2%	51.3%	5.5%

From the point of view of marketing strategy and the optimal choice of marketing mix, it is also necessary to propose the positioning for the selected target segments. The positioning of a product relates to its characteristics, the benefits it fulfils, and how it is differentiated from competitive products, which have a direct effect on customer repurchase intention and loyalty [80].

The positioning study [74] elaborates that rational motives influence game meat consumers' choice more than emotional factors, while the most critical motives are connected with healthcare issues, like in study [81]. The study [79] states that Central European consumers, especially younger ones, are more concerned with game price and sensory characteristics. In general, the taste, overall quality, and odour were the most important sensory characteristics of game meat appreciated by the consumers. The taste, nutritional value, and low-fat content are the essential attributes for buying decisions. The study [82] states that despite the high nutritional value and health benefits, the younger generation is reluctant to consume game.

Another study [83] states that for middle-segment meat products, the combination of the price level and level of attention to animal welfare is of key importance. This information needs to be visible on the packaged product. The study [84] states that the country of origin and quality labelling pertaining mainly to game's health appeal have great potential for differentiation in meat. In order to realise higher added value in the consumer market, it is, therefore, appropriate to present game with a certification of origin and meat processing. These brands will help customers orient themselves while increasing the value for consumers by reducing the uncertainty or the risk associated with a purchase. This is stated, for example, in [23,85].

Several studies have emphasised the cultural role and contribution to biodiversity of game [27,86] and have mentioned the monetary aspect of game production only as a secondary consequence. The above examples show several possible approaches to positioning, including the possibility of introducing brands.

In order to evaluate the relevance for the Czech Republic, further detailed research will be required that includes not only a more detailed analysis of the segmentation criteria but also an analysis of the attractiveness of the customer segments created, the evaluation and the selection of target segments, and the subsequent appropriate positioning for the selected target segments (see, e.g., [87,88]). However, the above results already show a relatively large demand potential among the segment of customers from larger cities in the case of packaged (frozen) venison with information on the organic quality and domestic origin of the meat using a brand that would become a guarantor of quality.

4. Conclusions

The main goal of this research was to identify the main marketing factors that influence the demand for game among the existing game consumers and, thus, obtain a starting point for further detailed research, proposals aimed at increasing demand through the more effective use of marketing mix tools, and a more detailed segmentation that would facilitate a more accurate targeting of marketing activities. To fulfil this purpose, research questions were formulated, the answers to which are summarized in the conclusion.

Our research results show that there are significant differences in game consumers given their demographic characteristics. Such differences we discovered between the behaviour of women and men, and, for example, between customers who prefer home preparation compared to consumption in a restaurant (see Tables 5 and 8). Differences

were also found in the relationship between education and place of game consumption, as well as between rural and urban residents. Apart from identifying the limiting factors on the customer side, the removal of which can more fundamentally change the demand for game on the consumer market side, our research has proven the existence of factors that reduce the intensity of consumer demand. Only a quarter of the respondents strongly agree with the statement (see Table 7) that game is a healthy organic food, while 60 % of the population rather agrees with this statement. Although the perception of the healthiness of venison is not likely the only or a sufficient argument for its purchase, there is an excellent opportunity to significantly support purchasing behaviours regarding game meat through appropriate and effective communication. The number of respondents who definitely agree with the statement that game is an ecologically friendly food, the consumption of which also helps Czech forests, is even smaller. In addition to communication aimed at overcoming prejudices and explaining some facts and contexts, there are other tools of the marketing mix, which are listed in the next question. Here, we summarise the marketing tools (product, price, distribution, and communication) that can significantly influence consumer demand in the game market. As for product, it is evident that residents of larger cities, in particular, would rather welcome butchered, portioned, or frozen meat (see Table 8). For price, if the game is not a direct sale from the hunter, the final price of the game cannot be influenced at the level of the forestry sector. The reason is that there is a huge difference between the purchase price of venison and the selling price that is ten times higher for the final product paid for by the consumer. Such a situation is not unique but can also be found in other countries (e.g., in Italy). The high share of game purchases (see Figure 5) indicates that a significant part of the game trade is based on personal ties, and for a large part of the population, game, in a processed form, is hardly available in the store. Therefore, increasing the intensity of the distribution and availability of game throughout the year is tied to the frozen form of the product. Such a situation creates an opportunity for communication through packaging and branding and conveying additional information to the consumer. Based on Table 5, Table 6, and Table 7, the following thematic areas focused on strengthening the positive image and refuting some experienced ideas are proposed for application as communication tools. Game is a healthy, safe organic food with an emphasis on the favourable ratio of quality versus price. Hunting is an activity necessary for the restoration of forests that also includes the care of game and observing ethical standards. The preparation of game is comparable to that of other commonly available meats, and a number of relatively simple recipes can liven up your daily menu.

Although some customers perceive game as healthy organic food, customers are not yet ready to pay for this quality. At the same time, customers are generally willing to pay extra for organic and regional foods for households and in the gastro segment [89–91]. More than two-thirds of customers prefer to buy fresh and cut game. If the sale of game is to increase, either the volume of the meat offered in this format must be increased, or the customer's preferences must be changed, for example, by explaining why game is easier to process in the frozen state.

At the same time, the demand for game is also influenced by its being offered in the retail network; almost half of the customers stated that they buy it in supermarkets/hypermarkets or from butchers. The customer rarely experiences a real impulse to try game. The solution may be a long-term campaign to promote consumption, which will slowly change food preferences and include game to a greater extent in the household diet.

Due to the high costs of similar types of campaigns, it is advisable to use the form of collective advertising, i.e., the joint advertising of entities, in our case, game producers with possible state support (justifying social interest, the connection with forest restoration, the use and evaluation of resources, and support for sustainability).

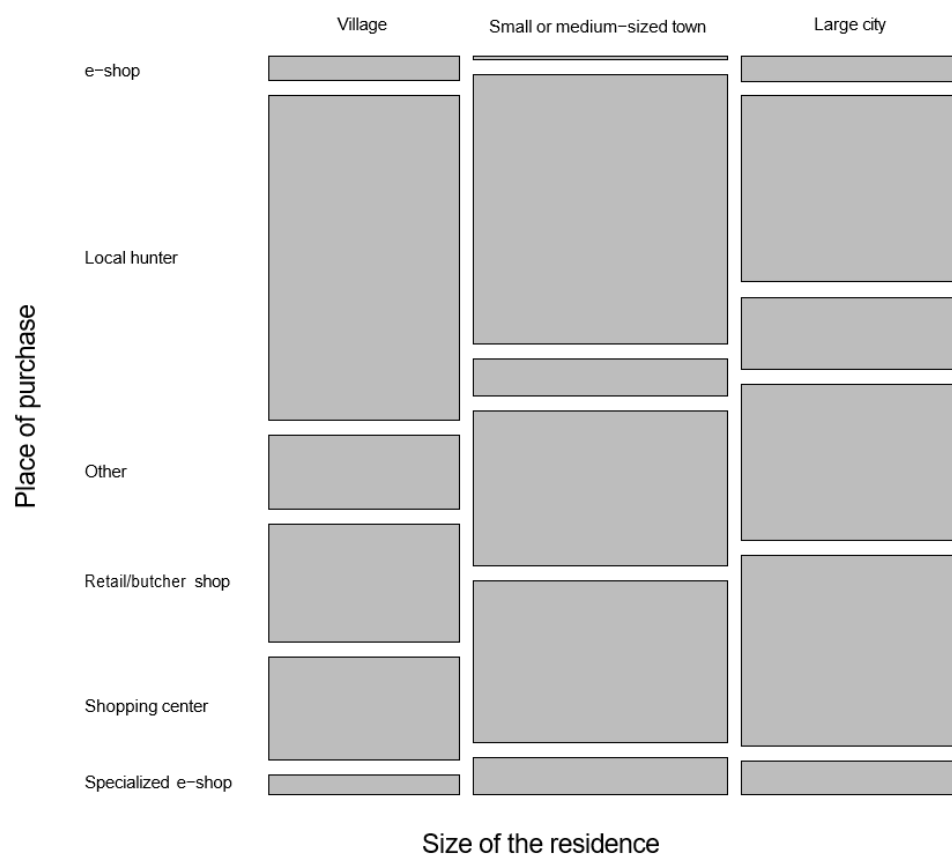


Figure 5. The mosaic display of the relationship between the size of the residence and the place the meat was purchased ($n = 472$). * A specialised e-shop is an e-shop that specialises in the sale of game meat only, whereas an e-shop is meant as a general grocery shop in our research.

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